

Pulse — a real-time rhythm co-op

Share the tempo, glance at the conductor. A band of RPG characters must drum out a shared emotional story on a living heartbeat — staying inside the swing envelope, handing off the baton when someone falters, never missing a beat.

Pulse turns **TTN-RFC-0010 (Fleet Pulse)** into a tabletop game. The RFC's robots keep a ~1 Hz heartbeat in tight phase *without messaging every beat*; Pulse asks 2–5 players to do the same with their hands and a metronome. The "chart" they play is the **Hero's Arc** from `feelings_ttdb.md` (@LAT88LON0): Serenity → Unease → Fear → Grief → Hope → Joy. Complete the arc as a band, in time, and you win.

- **Players:** 2–5
- **Length:** 15–25 min per story (a "set" is 3 stories)
- **Feel:** party-game tension of real-time timing, with a quiet emotional payoff
- **You need:** the card deck below, the token bag below, and a **pulse source** — a phone metronome, a clapping app, or one player as the human click track.

1. The core idea (straight from the RFC)

In Fleet Pulse, **the beat is computed, not received** — every node derives the grid from a shared clock and only "glances at the conductor" occasionally to trim drift. Pulse keeps that spirit:

RFC concept (TTN-RFC-0010)	Pulse rule
Shared pulse clock, ~1 Hz	A metronome everyone hears. The bar = 4 beats.
Beat is computed, wire carries the chart not the click	Players must play on the beat from their own internal count, not wait to be told.
Conductor: first-up starts it, keeps it; id breaks ties; era on handoff	One player holds the Baton. They set the bar's required beat and call the count-in. The Baton passes on failure, era ticks up.
±50 ms swing budget (drift_reserve vs. musical swing)	The timing window for a "clean" play. Hitting dead-center is fine; the band wants a little human swing, but too early/late = drift.
beat_mask — each part plays on specific beats of the bar	Each character has a Part card: which beat(s) of the 4-beat bar they're responsible for.
On-join fast-lock (extra beacon when a node arrives)	A new/returning player gets a free count-in to lock back in.
Resync pacing — correct only as drift demands	Drift tokens accumulate; you only stop to "resync" (spend a turn) when they pile up.
Graceful degradation — lose conductor, free-run on last chart	If the Baton-holder busts, the band keeps the beat for one bar while the baton hands off. No instant game-over.

The whole game is the RFC's slogan made physical: **you cannot succeed by reacting to each beat — you must hold the tempo internally and only look up when drift forces it.**

2. Components

2.1 The Story Track (the chart)

A 6-card strip laid face-up in the center — the Hero's Arc beats, in order:

1. **Serenity** @LAT10LON-10
2. **Unease** @LAT-10LON-10
3. **Fear** @LAT-30LON20
4. **Grief** @LAT-30LON-30
5. **Hope** @LAT20LON20
6. **Joy** @LAT30LON30

A shared **Story Marker** sits on the current beat. Advancing it to **Joy** wins.

2.2 Character cards (dispositions as classes)

Each player draws one RPG character. The card lists a **disposition** and a **reaches / strains** pair drawn from the Feelings TTDB edges:

Character	Disposition node	Reaches (play for -1 cost)	Strains (costs +1 Drift to play)
The Seeker	Curiosity @LAT10LON40	Unease, Hope	Grief
The Warden	Suspicion @LAT-20LON-30	Fear, Grief	Joy
The Healer	Compassion @LAT30LON40	Hope, Joy	Fear
The Hermit	Equanimity @LAT30LON-20	Serenity, Grief	Hope
The Trickster	Indifference @LAT-10LON-40	Fear, Unease	Joy, Hope

Why this forces cooperation: no single character can carry all six beats cheaply. The Warden powers through Fear and Grief but chokes on Joy; the Healer lands Hope and Joy but strains at Fear. The band has to route each beat to whoever *reaches* it — and hand off the Baton accordingly.

2.3 Part cards (the beat_mask)

Dealt one per player at the start of each story. Your Part says which beat(s) of the 4-beat bar are **yours to play**:

Part	beat_mask	Role (RFC §7.1 voicing)
Hi-hat	beats 1·2·3·4	timekeeper — plays every bar, the band's spine
Lead	beat 1 (downbeat)	sounds the story-beat advance
Backbeat	beats 2 & 4	the groove; covers the conductor on handoff
Rim	beat 3	the offbeat accent

With 2–3 players, combine masks so every beat of the bar is covered by someone.

2.4 Feeling cards (your hand)

A shared draw deck of Feeling cards matching the six arc emotions (plus near-neighbors from the field: Contentment, Melancholy, Frustration, Excitement...). You hold **3**.

2.5 Tokens

- **Pulse tokens** ×7 (shared) — the band's "life." Lose one on a missed/doubled beat.
- **Drift tokens** (shared pool) — accumulate from sloppy or strained plays; too many forces a **Resync**.
- **The Baton** ×1 — marks the conductor. Has an **era dial** (a d10 or a counter), starts at 1, ticks up on every handoff.
- **Swing tokens** ×3 (shared) — earned by clean play, spent to "swing" (see §4.4).

3. Setup

1. Lay the **Story Track** (6 beats), Story Marker on **Serenity**.
 2. Each player draws a **Character** and a **Part** card, and **3 Feeling cards**.
 3. Put **7 Pulse tokens** in the center, the Drift pool empty, **3 Swing tokens** aside.
 4. **First-up is conductor (RFC §3.1)**: whoever most recently kept a beat (drummed, tapped, hummed) takes the **Baton**, era = 1. Ties break to the youngest player (your "lowest-id" rule — pick any deterministic tie-break and keep it all game).
 5. Start the metronome at a **gentle tempo** (≈ 60 BPM, one beat per second). You can speed up between stories.
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4. How a bar works

A **bar** is 4 metronome beats. Everything happens in time with the click.

4.1 Count-in (the Baton-holder's job)

On beat **4** of the previous bar, the conductor calls the **required emotion** for the next bar — it must be the Story Marker's **current** beat or the **next** one on the track (you can only advance by a legal edge). This is the conductor "announcing the chart."

4.2 Playing your beat

When *your* beat (per your Part's beat_mask) comes around, you must **lay a Feeling card face-up onto the Story Track** in time with the click:

- **On time** (within the swing window — i.e. on the click, give or take a hair): clean.
- **A legal card** = a Feeling that matches the required emotion **or** sits on a typed edge toward it (resonates_with, can_deepen_into, intensifies_into).
- Play a card your character **Reaches**: no cost (and you may take a **Swing token** if the play was clean).
- Play a card your character **Strains**: add **+1 Drift** to the pool (you did it, but it cost the band tightness).

4.3 What goes wrong (lose a Pulse token)

- **Missed beat** — your beat passed and you played nothing, or played late/early enough to be off the click: **-1 Pulse token, +1 Drift**.
- **Doubled beat** — two players play on the same beat (collision): **-1 Pulse token**. (The RFC's (src, seq) dedup, dramatized: two nodes can't own the same slot.)
- **Illegal advance** — a card that doesn't reach the required emotion: doesn't count; the beat is treated as missed.

4.4 Swing (the ±50 ms is *feel*, not slop — RFC §6)

Spend a **Swing token** to deliberately **lay back or push** a play — land it a touch late (relaxed) or early (urgent) **on purpose** and still count it clean, *and* draw an extra Feeling card. This is the RFC's point that the tolerance is "expressive headroom, not uncorrected error": good bands use the window, they don't just survive it.

4.5 Advancing the story

At the end of a bar, if the **downbeat (Lead) play** legally matched the required emotion, move the **Story Marker** forward one beat on the arc. Reach **Joy** = the band wins the story.

5. Conductor handoff (the heart of the game)

This is the RFC's election model (§3) turned into the cooperative engine.

- **Trigger a handoff** when the conductor's own beat **busts** (missed/illegal on the beat they were responsible for), **or** voluntarily when the next required emotion is one the conductor **Strains** but a teammate **Reaches**.
- **Graceful degradation (RFC §3.4)**: the band does **not** stop. The **Backbeat** part holds the next bar's groove (free-run on the last chart) while the baton moves.
- **Who takes it**: the new conductor must be someone who **Reaches** the upcoming emotion. Among eligible

- players, lowest-id (your fixed tie-break) takes the baton.
- **era ticks up.** Increment the Baton's era dial. A higher era "wins" — so a player who busted out can't immediately grab the baton back (no flapping, RFC §3.4).
- **On-join fast-lock (RFC §4.2):** the new conductor gets a **free count-in bar** to settle before play resumes — the band glances at the new timekeeper.

The story literally cannot finish unless the baton travels to the right character for each emotional beat. The Warden carries you through **Fear** and **Grief**; you *must* hand off to the Healer or Seeker to land **Hope**, and to the Healer for **Joy**. The band's job is to route the conductor role around the arc.

6. Resync (paced by drift, not by tempo — RFC §5)

You don't stop every bar to tidy up — only when drift threatens the swing budget.

- When the **Drift pool reaches 3**, the band must **Resync** at the top of the next bar: skip one bar of story advancement, discard all Drift tokens, and the conductor re-calls the count. The metronome keeps running — you just spend a bar re-tightening.
 - A Resync **costs no Pulse token** (it's maintenance, not failure) but it costs *tempo*: you lose ground on a timed set (see §8).
 - This mirrors the RFC's "correct only as often as drift demands": the band that plays cleanly (mostly **Reaches** plays, good handoffs) almost never resyncs; a band forcing **Strains** plays resyncs constantly and runs out the clock.
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7. Winning and losing

- **Win the story:** advance the Story Marker to **Joy** with at least one Pulse token left.
 - **Lose the story:** Pulse tokens hit **0** — the band fell apart; the heartbeat stopped.
 - **Win the set:** complete **3 stories**, raising the tempo each time (60 → 80 → 100 BPM). The band that holds the groove as it gets faster has truly locked in.
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8. Variants & scaling

- **Solo / 2-player:** one player covers two Parts (combine `beat_masks`); the Baton still passes between *characters* you hold.
 - **Timed set (advanced):** put a 3-minute timer on each story. Every Resync burns table time — now the RFC's "tight band, idle wire" becomes "tight band, time to spare." A sloppy band beats the clock with no margin.
 - **Conductor-loss drill (RFC §10 test 5):** once per set the active player may "power off" — sit out a bar without warning. The band must hand the baton off mid-bar and keep the beat. Survive it for a bonus Swing token.
 - **Adaptive tempo:** if the band clears two bars with zero Drift, the conductor *may* nudge the metronome up a notch — the RFC's optional adaptive pacing (§5).
 - **Full Metamorphosis crossover:** carry your Character's evolved hand into a game of [Metamorphosis](#) — the emotions you learned to *Reach* in Pulse become beliefs you can consolidate.
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9. Quick reference card

A BAR = 4 metronome beats. YOUR BEAT = your Part's `beat_mask`.

ON YOUR BEAT, in time with the click:
 play a Feeling card that REACHES/EDGES the required emotion.
 Reaches -> clean, take a Swing token
 Strains -> +1 Drift
 miss / late / illegal -> -1 Pulse, +1 Drift
 two players same beat -> -1 Pulse (collision)

CONDUCTOR (Baton): calls next emotion on beat 4; must Reach it.

busts or strains -> hand baton to someone who Reaches it; era +1;
Backbeat holds the groove; new conductor gets a free count-in.

DRIFT hits 3 -> Resync: skip a bar, clear Drift, re-count.

SWING token: spend to push/lay-back a play on purpose -> still clean + draw a card.

WIN story: reach JOY with ≥ 1 Pulse left. LOSE: Pulse hits 0.

WIN set: 3 stories, tempo 60 -> 80 -> 100 BPM.

Source mechanics: RFCs/TTN-RFC-0010-Fleet-Pulse.md (heartbeat, conductor election, swing budget, beat_mask parts, resync pacing) and feelings_ttdb.md (the Hero's Arc chart @LAT88LON0, dispositions, typed edges). See [IDEAS.md](#) for the full game catalog.